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Author(s): Michael Paul Gallagher

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Lonergan's Newman: Appropriated Affinities

«We not only feel, and think, and reason, but we know that we feel, and think, and reason; not only know, but can inspect and ascertain our thoughts, feelings, and reasonings: not only ascertain, but describe» (Newman 1840).¹

«My fundamental mentor and guide has been John Henry Newman's *Grammar of Assent* [... I] found Newman's presentation to be something that fitted in with the way I knew things. It was from that kernel that I went on to different authors» (Lonergan, 1978).²

It is well known that as a young student of philosophy at Heythrop College, in England, Bernard Lonergan came across the work of John Henry Newman and avidly read *The Grammar of Assent* several times during his years there. At an early stage of his stay in Heythrop, Lonergan wrote to a Jesuit friend that he was «little scholastic» but that the «theory of knowledge is what is going to interest me most of all». ³ Within this double context – the alienation from the dominant scholasticism and the hunch that his natural bent was for epistemology – one best can appreciate Newman's impact on him. This discovery served as a liberation from the abstractions which had induced disappointment in the brilliant young Canadian. It was the beginning of a quiet but never passive discipleship that was to last a lifetime.

¹ J.H. NEWMAN, *Fifteen Sermons preached before the University of Oxford*, London, 1887, 256. This comes from the sermon «Implicit and Explicit Reason» referred to by Lonergan in his 1929 student paper (as explained later here).

² B. LONERGAN, *Philosophical and Theological Papers 1965-1980*, CWL 17, eds. R.C. Croken, R.M. Doran, Toronto, 2004, 388.

³ Letter of June 20 1927, quoted by R.M. LIDDY, *Transforming Light: intellectual conversion in the early Lonergan*, Collegeville, 1993, 32.

Many years later, on the closing page of his philosophical masterwork, *Insight*, Lonergan remarked that he had spent many years reaching up to the mind of Aquinas, only to discover that the long process of that research had changed him, and that such a transformation of horizon was the essential fruit. On the road to this intellectual conversion Newman had been his first mentor. In Lonergan's own words, his «interest in Aquinas came late», mainly in the 1940s, and subsequent to three major influences in his younger years: Newman during the twenties, and Plato and Augustine «in the early thirties».⁴

Comments on this early impact of Newman are scattered throughout the Canadian's writings, as for example in our second epigraph above. Also in a paper of 1973 he recalled his period as a philosophy student in England and added:

«[I] read several times the more theoretical passages in Newman's *A Grammar of Assent*. Newman's remark that ten thousand difficulties do not make a doubt has served me in good stead. It encouraged me to look difficulties squarely in the eye, while not letting them interfere with my vocation or my faith. His illative sense later became my reflective act of understanding» (2C 263).

The style here betrays a certain casualness, indicative of someone gathering memories long past. The Newman dictum on doubts does not in fact occur in the *Grammar* but towards the beginning of Chapter 5 of the *Apologia pro Vita Sua*, and the reference to it seems a digression. The key issue is the identification of the illative sense with Lonergan's third moment of cognitional structure. This is the culmination of the theoretical passages in the *Grammar* and in Lonergan's later epistemology, the act of verifying an affirmation is the key to his defence of the objectivity of truth.

In an essay of thirty years earlier entitled «The Form of Inference» (adapting in fact one of his student papers from Heythrop days), he commented that Newman's «illative sense proceeds along ways unknown to syllogism from a cumulation of probabilities – too manifold to be marshaled, too fleeting to be formulated – to a conclusion that nonetheless is certain».⁵ In its own words the *Grammar* moves away from a logic based on «a smart syllogism» to a more truly human road of understanding which might be «a condition of a true conversion».⁶ In another essay of 1943, Lonergan's study of marriage, he again records his positive evaluation of «the unanalyzed type of inference Newman termed the illative sense».⁷ In all this he had put

⁴ B. LONERGAN, *A Second Collection*, eds. W.F. Ryan, B.J. Tyrrell, London, 1974, 38. Future references to this book will be given in the text with the abbreviation 2C.

⁵ B. LONERGAN, *Collection*, CWL 4, eds. Fr.E. Crowe, R.M. Doran, Toronto, 1988, 4.

⁶ J.H. NEWMAN, *An Essay in aid of a Grammar of Assent*, London, 1909, 425. Future references will be given in the text with the abbreviation GA.

⁷ *Collection*, 48 n.

his finger on a crucial strand in Newman's thought, and one which was central long before the *Grammar*: the *University Sermons*, also known to the young Lonergan as we shall see, were Newman's principal exploration of the non-explicit character of the mind's operations.

Although in his later life Lonergan fairly frequently referred to Newman, he seems to have had a number of key sentences or ideas in mind, and he never expanded at length on their significance for him. Apart from his important student paper of 1929, which had Newman as a central interlocutor, and apart from a lost manuscript of some 30,000 words, written some five years later and which was largely devoted to Newman, we are left with these pithy statements concerning the importance of Newman for him. Most surprising of all is the silence about Newman in *Insight*. Some commentators have pointed to the fact that Lonergan in the introduction and again on the final page describes his book as «essay in aid of» personal appropriation, thus echoing the full title of the *Grammar*.⁸ But this hardly constitutes a major acknowledgement of the relevance of Newman. What are we to make of this absence of direct or detailed commentary on Newman on the part of Lonergan? The hypothesis of this article is suggested in its title: it is a question of appropriated affinities. Even in the case of his detailed interpretative dialogue with Aquinas, Lonergan's tendency was to assimilate and to move on. New references to Aquinas decrease as the years go on. Similarly any exploration of the relationship between Newman and Lonergan needs to take into account how an initially explicit enthusiasm became integrated into an implicit horizon. There are many key issues in the *Grammar* as well as in the *University Sermons* on which Lonergan never openly comments, but which became constants in his own later positions. This is not simply a question of influence, and even less of borrowing. It seems rather a case of affinities recognised, appropriated and then creatively developed in new directions.

What, then, was the essential benefit from that early immersion in the work of Newman? It seems to have been first and foremost a confirming self-discovery. Here was an exploratory genius of the previous century who

⁸ B. LONERGAN, *Insight: a study of human understanding*, CWL 3, eds. Fr.E. Crowe, R.M. Doran, Toronto, 1992, 16, 769. Future references to this edition of *Insight* will be given in the text with the abbreviation *Ins*. William Mathews, author of the long-awaited and forthcoming biography of Lonergan, informs me that there was a section in the text entitled «Intelligence and Reality», a precursor of *Insight* from the years 1951-53, which dealt with Newman on judgement. This is interestingly different from the comment of the then elderly Lonergan that «I don't mention Newman in *Insight* [...] because I would have had to explain what Newman said» (*Caring about Meaning: patterns in the life of Bernard Lonergan*, eds. P. Lambert, C. Tansey, C. Going, Montreal, 1982, 109). One might ask whether Lonergan ever explained what Newman said; his tendency to make only fleeting references to his nineteenth-century mentor indicates deep affinities rather than in-depth interpretations.

took seriously the new challenges to religious knowing and who sought to answer them not by ahistorical logic, or by citing authorities from the past, but by reflection on the movements of the mind at work. This empirical and introspective focus, together with a sense of psychological realism about the justification needed for religious faith, strongly attracted the young Lonergan. What the Heythrop philosophy student found in Newman was a question and a method. The question concerned the possibility of arriving at religious certitude in an epoch when scientific procedures seemed to monopolise the road to truth. The method was a non-deductive reflection on the operations of ordinary knowing. Of Newman, however, it could be said, as Lonergan later remarked about Aristotle, that he practised introspection but offered «no account of introspective method» (2C, 48).

Status Questionis

At this stage an overview of previous research in this area may prove fruitful. In 1969 Frederick Crowe, Lonergan's most authoritative interpreter, remarked that «a study should be made of Lonergan's relation to Newman».⁹ In fact there have been important essays on this relationship in each of the last three decades. The intention here is not to list every author who has touched on the Newman-Lonergan connection, but simply to indicate the main perspectives of previous commentators in this area. Writing in 1977, George Worgul noted that both authors «use the actual performance of the human mind as their starting point» and that they highlight «the ultimately personal character of truth».¹⁰ He also mentioned some differences between them: Newman adopted a more literary style to embody a subjective process of thought, whereas Lonergan was a scientist propounding a more objective and systematic viewpoint. In Worgul's opinion Lonergan moved away from the influence of Newman during the writing of *Insight*, but returned to it in *Method in Theology*, especially in his treatment of how on the fourth or existential level, «consciousness becomes conscience».¹¹ In the late eighties David Hammond developed the argument further, with the advantage of having access to many of Lonergan's unpublished papers. He was therefore able to explore, among other valuable new data, the Heythrop student essays and some fragments from a long essay on Newman in the early 1930s. Hammond notes that even in his Heythrop days Lonergan, encouraged by Newman, had focussed on the importance both of «knowing one's own operations» and of an «existential concern for the standpoint of

⁹ Fr.E. CROWE, *Appropriating the Lonergan Idea*, ed. M. Vertin, Washington, 1989, 180.

¹⁰ G.S. WORGUL, «The Ghost of Newman in the Lonergan Corpus» in *The Modern Schoolman* 54 (1977) 317-332. Quotations from 319, 323.

¹¹ *Ibid.*, 331, where he is quoting from *Method*, 268.

the one who judges».¹² From the surviving pieces of the lost paper he quotes a highly significant question: «Does not this doctrine of assent bring us to the very core of the drama of Christianity?».¹³ In other words, Lonergan had found in Newman his strongest ally in his search for a phenomenology of truth capable of including the act of faith.

In 1992 Edward Jeremy Miller proposed that both Newman and Lonergan shared certain approaches that marked them as critics of the narrow agenda of post-Enlightenment philosophy: in particular they underlined the connection between moral disposition or conscience and the self-correcting process of moving towards truth.¹⁴ The following year Richard Liddy published his masterly book on the early Lonergan, including a substantial chapter on Newman. Like Hammond, he made extensive use of unpublished material and offered a detailed account of the student paper which Lonergan wrote in 1929. Entitled «True Judgment and Science», it contains, in Liddy's words, «the most ample references to Newman in all of Lonergan's extant writings».¹⁵ The next year again, Carla Mae Streeter wrote a shorter piece arguing that Newman and Lonergan shared both an apologetic purpose and a phenomenological approach. She rightly insisted that Lonergan went beyond his mentor in facing the challenges of culture and in particular through his reinterpretation of Aquinas.¹⁶ In 1996 Philip Egan produced a fine synthesis of research in this whole area, noting that there were some «eighty of so references to Newman in Lonergan's books, articles and interviews» and offering a careful account of the evolution of this explicit interaction between the two thinkers.¹⁷ In 1999 Ulf Jonsson accurately summarised the growing consensus: «inspired by his reading of Newman, Lonergan already in the late 1920s arrived at the conviction that the key epistemic act in human cognition is the act of passing judgment».¹⁸

The present contribution builds on the excellent work of these colleagues and is in substantial agreement with their insights and conclusions. It hopes to carry the argument further by revisiting the *Grammar* and (for

¹² D.M. HAMMOND, «The Influence of Newman's Doctrine of Assent on the Thought of Bernard Lonergan: A Genetic Study» in *Method. Journal of Lonergan Studies* 7 (1989) 95 -115. Quotation from 99.

¹³ *Ibid.*, 104.

¹⁴ E.J. MILLER, «The Role of Moral Dispositions in the Cognitive Theories of Newman and Lonergan» in *Thought* 67 (1992) 128-147.

¹⁵ R.M. LIDDY, *Transforming Light*, 24.

¹⁶ C.M. STREETER, «The Lonergan Connection with Newman's *Grammar*» in *Personality and Belief: Interdisciplinary Essays on John Henry Newman*, Lanham, 1994, 174-183.

¹⁷ P.A. EGAN, «Lonergan on Newman's Conversion» in *Heythrop Journal* 37 (1996) 437-455. Quotation from 438.

¹⁸ U. JONSSON, *Foundations for Knowing God: Bernard Lonergan's Foundations for Knowledge of God and the Challenge from Anti-Foundationalism*, Frankfurt, 1999, 331.

the first time) the *University Sermons* in the light of Lonergan's typical concerns. It will thus suggest a different angle of interpretation of the affinity between the two authors. Many of these parallels were not explored in previous studies because they concentrated mainly on points in Newman explicitly mentioned by Lonergan. A first section will revisit that story of Lonergan's liberating discovery of Newman, which will form the basis for identifying the major convergences between these two thinkers. Then we will be in a position to see where Lonergan transcends his Newmanian starting points, but in ways that would surely have pleased his nineteenth-century predecessor. The aim is to make explicit the re-interpretation of Newman that continues implicitly in Lonergan's work. We shall be asking not only what was received from the older thinker, but in what ways the disciple assimilated and transformed that inheritance.

Early Lonergan: towards criteria of certitude

In his mid twenties, hence at almost exactly the same age as was Lonergan in Heythrop, the young Newman had delivered his first «university sermon», and had begun by voicing his concern about criteria of truth. In a cultural context dominated by science how can one justify the different knowing involved in religious faith? The opening words of the young Oxford preacher sound like a manifesto: «Few charges have been more frequently urged by unbelievers against Revealed Religion, than that it is hostile to the advance of philosophy and science».¹⁹ And this sermon ends with the first mention of what would become a key idea in Newman's defence of religious certainty as grounded in «accumulated probabilities». Lonergan's third Heythrop paper,²⁰ entitled «True Judgement and Science», confronts the same problem and in much the same spirit arrives at similar conclusions: the danger outlined, in the opening sentences of the paper, was that «certitude is restricted to scientific conclusions», but «if true judgment may be consciously true, then science ceases to be the one measure of certitude».²¹

¹⁹ J.H. NEWMAN, *Fifteen Sermons preached before the University of Oxford*, London, 1887, 1. Future references will be given in the text with the abbreviation *US*.

²⁰ Lonergan had presented two other topics in the *Blandyke Papers* in 1927 and 1928, «The Form of Mathematical Inference» and «The Syllogism», which seem to have preceded his discovery of Newman.

²¹ I quote this paper from a photocopy of the original handwritten version available in the Lonergan Centre at Milltown Park, Dublin. This quotation comes from p. 1. Future references will be given in the text with the abbreviation *TJS*. In the book already mentioned, R. Liddy's chapter on Lonergan and Newman offers useful quotations from this text. Indeed nearly forty years ago I came across the original copy of that student publication in the library of Heythrop College, then still in Oxfordshire. At that time a group of philosophy students there discovered Lonergan rather as he had discovered Newman – outside the official curriculum – and he became a source of subversive consolation whenever we were dissatisfied with the philosophy being taught in that same institution!

Immediately the focus falls on awareness of the operations of the subject rather than on proof about an object, a theme that would be explored and deepened by the later Lonergan. Moreover, the concern about a reductive version of scientific truth continued also in his later years, even in some of his popular writing. For instance, when in 1953 Lonergan produced a short article on «Respect for Human Dignity», which was one of the intentions of the apostolate of prayer, he singled out a positivistic epistemology as a main threat to human dignity. Whether the readers of the *Messenger of the Sacred Heart* understood him or not, his argument was pure Lonergan and in many ways a development of Newman:

«There are the old scientists who took it for granted that the real is what is out there [...]. There are also the new scientists, and they are committed to a quite different view of reality, knowledge, and objectivity [...]. So it comes about that scientific knowledge is a matter of knowing what is true; and strangely, what is true is not what one can see or imagine, but only what one can conceive intelligently and affirm reasonably».²²

This defence of an alternative epistemology, rooted in the operations of human intelligence and in the moral thrust of human freedom, is Lonergan's mature elaboration on what he had first learned from Newman.

Turning back to the 1929 paper, it is clear that Newman had enthused the young Canadian, not only by pinpointing a crisis in the criteria of truth, but by indicating a valid solution for it. On at least a dozen occasions the Heythrop paper quotes from *The Grammar of Assent* or gives references to precise pages of that book. Lonergan manages to capture the core of the book's argument and to paraphrase it neatly in his own words. Thus the illative sense is described as an ability of the «mind in the function of judging inferences» (TJS 195), allowing us to meet this «question in the spirit though not in the letter of rationality» (TJS 196). In this way one can respond to the «origin of the rationalism» criticised by Newman, and which allows people to be «complacently agnostic in the high name of reason» (TJS 213). He echoes Newman's typical appeal to everyday operations: as against the intransigence of a certain scientism, «we take ourselves as we find ourselves» and reflect on «our ordinary procedure», trusting that the ordinary «mind judges rather than syllogises» (TJS 201, 203). With an eloquence and synthetic power surprising in a young writer, he critiques the 'degradation' of judgement that came from an over-estimation of science, and he gathers his argument together in these words:

«To sum up the argument, nature does not fail us in necessities, a criterion of

²² B. LONERGAN, «Respect for Human Dignity» in *The Canadian Messenger of the Sacred Heart* 63 (1953) 413-417. Quotation from 414.

evidence is necessary, science, the syllogistic method, shows itself to be inadequate [...]. The alternative criterion is the mind itself [...]. Not science so much as wisdom is to be the individual's aim [...]. Before science was discovered and philosophers appeared, true judgement [...] constituted the sole way to truth» (TJS 209, 211).

Interestingly, the paper quotes several commentators on Newman, thus showing that Lonergan had researched in the secondary literature. Among these he seems to have been especially impressed by Henri Bremond's *The Mystery of Newman*, a book much criticised later as offering too aesthetic an interpretation of the down-to-earth Englishman. However, one quotation from Bremond is of particular interest in view of Lonergan's later directions in theology:

«Life alone can judge life; only a theology which is concrete real and full of religious feeling can discern the untruth and unreality of doctrine which calls itself religious but which is not. The touchstone used by such living theology is not the abstract possibility, the logical coherence but the moral richness of the system» (TJS 208).

The University Sermons

Although the major dialogue with Newman in this paper of February 1929 draws frequently on Lonergan's reading of *The Grammar of Assent*, interestingly there is one reference to the university sermons. So we know that the young Lonergan had also consulted these rich explorations on the relation of faith and reason. In fact Newman's university sermons, dating from thirty and more years previous to the *Grammar*, had already laid the foundations of his later book, and often expressed his insights in a more lively and communicative manner.

Lonergan's one reference to the university sermons is only a page reference, not a direct quotation, and it occurs in a passage where he is discussing the possibility of objective truth in Greek philosophy. He comments that for «Plato the basis of science, the absolute premise was the Good and Plato refused to put down this fundamental doctrine in writing simply because it could not be adequately expressed» (TJS 212). At that point he gives three references, two of them to Newman: «Burnet, *Greek Philosophy*, 221, Newman, *University Sermons*, 275, *Arians of 4th Century*, 137». The passage indicated in the university sermons is a crucial and eloquent one towards the close of what is probably the most important of the series, dating from 1840 and entitled «Implicit and Explicit Reason». Let me quote a substantial section of this page with its argument in favour of an alternative avenue towards truth, different from the dominant model of scientific verification:

«It is hardly too much to say, that almost all reasons formally adduced in moral inquiries, are rather specimens and symbols of the real grounds, than those

grounds themselves. They do but approximate to a representation of the general character of the proof which the writer wishes to convey to another's mind. They cannot, like mathematical proof, be passively followed with an attention confined to what is stated, and with the admission of nothing but what is urged. Rather, they are hints towards, and samples of, the true reasoning, and demand an active, ready, candid, and docile mind, which can throw itself into what is said, neglect verbal difficulties, and pursue and carry out principles. This is the true office of a writer, to excite and direct trains of thought; and this, on the other hand, is the too common practice of readers, to expect every thing to be done for them, – to refuse to think, – to criticize the letter, instead of reaching forwards towards the sense, – and to account every argument as unsound which is illogically worded» (US 275).

One can see immediately how such a position was grist for Lonergan's mill, and not only in the immediate context of his student paper with its defence of non-scientific judgement as an avenue of truth. Newman is highlighting here two central strands of his religious epistemology: the richness of human thought that cannot be captured in syllogistic or scientific clarities, and the necessity of a receptive disposition if one is to arrive at concrete truth in the area of personal meaning.

The reference to Newman's work on the Arians is more recondite and offers evidence of Lonergan's wide reading of his nineteenth-century mentor. The page mentioned contains one of Newman's typical criticisms of those who adopt a «fiercely argumentative way» to discuss religious truths «in the medium of controversy or proof». It goes on to question whether books, as distinct from personal communication, can ever do justice to themes of a «moral nature», which have their best home in «the Christian's heart» and hence require «to be treated with delicacy and discrimination».²³ What Lonergan found in these two passages was support for his argument that the conditions of possibility of fruitful God-talk called for a different rationality. Once more we have an instance of his interpreting Newman as an encouraging paradigm, pointing towards a more adequate epistemology of «true judgement». The detailed working out of his contribution to that field was to take years. But already from his earliest encounter with Newman he had, so to speak, a patron for his future developments.

No previous commentator on the relationship of Lonergan to Newman has given attention to this small but significant fact that the 1929 essay refers to the *University Sermons* and in particular to the 1840 text entitled «Explicit and Implicit Reason». Therefore it seems worthwhile to devote some more attention to this sermon here. It is arguably the most brilliant of the series of five conferences on faith and reason which Newman delivered

²³ J.H. NEWMAN, *The Arians of the Fourth Century*, London, 1891, 136-138.

between 1839 and 1841, and is an important precursor of *The Grammar of Assent* of exactly thirty years later. It summarises Newman's goal to show that argument or proofs for faith are always secondary to a primordial wavelength of knowing which is both tacit and universal. It invites its audience to recognise how they employ reasoning to reach truths of many kinds in daily life, without any apparatus of argumentative or formal reasoning. Indeed the focus of apologetics, in Newman's view, often fails to touch on the «real reasons» for faith. As he puts it in the previous sermon of the series, «We believe because we love» (US 236). To savour the lucid eloquence of Newman's presentation, it will suffice to quote some of his key sentences (in addition to what has already appeared in the first epigraph to this article), putting in italics some expressions that are closely echoed by Lonergan even in his later writings:

There is a «difference between the more simple faculties and *operations of the mind*, and that process of analyzing and describing them, which takes place upon reflection» (US 256).

«The mind ranges to and fro, and spreads out, and advances forward with a quickness which has become a proverb, and a subtlety and versatility which baffle investigation» (US 257). Here Newman goes on to offer one of his celebrated metaphors of the movement of thought as akin to an expert «clamberer» on a mountain, guided by a certain inward instinct, «how he knows not himself».

«The exercise of Reason is a *living spontaneous energy* within us, not an art. But when *the mind reflects upon itself*, it begins to be dissatisfied with the absence of order and *method in the exercise*» (US 257).

«The analysis [...] does not make the *conclusion correct*» (US 259).

«We *believe* certain things, on certain grounds, *through certain informants*». But no explicit analysis does justice to «the state of mind under which we believe» (US 263, 267).

An excessively academic theology undervalues the «instinctive feeling which commands the mind» leading it «to *mistake system for truth*, and to suppose than *an hypothesis is real* because it is consistent» (US 266).

«Who shall give *method* to what is infinitely complex?» (US 268).

The young Lonergan would have relished this largely phenomenological approach, so different from the conceptualism which had alienated him, and he would equally have found congenial its defence of a spontaneously non-scientific wavelength of reasoning. Of course he was to advance into other territory, giving method to the complex operations of the cognitional process. Two quotations from Lonergan will serve to establish the parallels, as well as the different horizons of a methodologist:

«As human knowing begins from natural *spontaneity*, so its initial developments are *inarticulate*» (Ins, 370).

«Before inquiry brings the pattern to light [...] the pattern is already conscious

and *operative*. *Spontaneously* we move from experiencing to the effort to understand».²⁴

There is also a case to be made that Newman's emphasis on the pre-conceptual realm is a forerunner of Lonergan's much more systematic exploration of affectivity, interiority, and realms of elemental meaning where symbols have «the power of recognizing and expressing what logical discourse abhors: the existence of internal tensions, incompatibilities, conflicts, struggles, destructions» (MT 66).

Twelve areas of convergence

If one revisits the text of *The Grammar of Assent* in search of what might have excited the young Lonergan, one finds many points of emphasis that must have confirmed the Heythrop student both in his disillusion with the system and in his quest for a more worthy wavelength in philosophy. Apart from the passages of Newman cited in the 1929 paper, one discovers several major themes in Newman that would, directly or indirectly, prove fruitful in Lonergan's later thought. We can list twelve of such areas.

The limitations of logic.²⁵ Newman was often scathing about logic in a narrow sense and quipped that «men become personal when logic fails» (GA 369). In tune with this is a well-known expression in the *Apologia*: «it is the concrete being that reasons [...] the whole man moves; paper logic is but the record of it».²⁶ On at least two occasions in the *Grammar* he uses the same metaphor to capture how mere logic is «unreal»: its effect is to «starve» living realities into «abstract notions» and so to drain words of their potential depth, poetry and «historical life» (GA 31, 267). This was directly quoted in Lonergan's 1929 paper. The young Lonergan seems to have resonated strongly with such distrust of abstraction and with Newman's defence of the possibility of a non-notional wavelength of personal exploration which would allow for «the record of experiences [...] inflaming the imagination, piercing the heart» (GA 10). The only direct quotation from Newman in Lonergan's *Method in Theology* comes from a satirical text of 1841 (which Newman re-used at some length in the *Grammar*): «logic makes but a sorry rhetoric with the multitude; first shoot round corners and you may not despair of converting by a syllogism» (MT 338). At this point in *Method* Lonergan is advancing his thesis that objectivity is reached through authen-

²⁴ B. LONERGAN, *Method in Theology*, London, 1972, 18. Future references will be given in the text with the abbreviation MT.

²⁵ One should not give the impression that Lonergan was hostile to all forms of logic. In the summer of 1957 at Boston College he offered two rather different courses, one on existentialism and the other on mathematical logic.

²⁶ J.H. NEWMAN, *Apologia pro Vita Sua*, ed. M. J. Svaglic, Oxford, 1967, 155.

tic subjectivity, and is therefore attacking the counter-position that seeks an objectivity forgetful of the lived process of knowing. He also seems to echo Newman when he insists that the operations involved in method «are not limited to strictly logical operations» (MT 6) and that these non-logical operations include «the presence or absence of verification» (2C 270). That we can arrive at affirmations or judgements in ways not amenable to formal logic is a position shared by both authors.

Prioritizing the concrete. If a distrust of any monopoly of the roads to truth by conventional logic is common to both thinkers, the more positive side of the coin is their shared focus on concrete procedures of thought. As already outlined, In the university sermon mentioned by Lonergan, Newman had stressed the difference between implicit and explicit reasoning. Although the *Grammar* does not use these words so prominently, he insists again that explicit logic «is not in fact the method by which we are enabled to become certain of what is concrete». He repeats another key insight of his early years: to reach certainty is a question of a «cumulation of probabilities» and this process is «too subtle and circuitous to be convertible into syllogisms» (288). Here Lonergan would have found encouragement for his own preference for experiential clarity and for examining the procedures of knowing that bring him to what he would later call the virtually unconditioned. More important still is Lonergan's development of Newman's intuitions about the contrast between theoretical and personalist reflection. As *Method* would put it, «the issue is a transition from the abstract logic of classicism to the concreteness of method. On the former view what is basic is proof. On the latter view what is basic is conversion [...]. If one considers logical proof to be basic, one wants an objectivity that is independent of the concrete existing subject» (MT 338). The key terms here are reminiscent of Newman, but the horizon has shifted towards what Lonergan calls interiority.

The intellect at work. In the manualistic approach to philosophy at Heythrop in the 1920's there was little or no attention to the actual workings of the mind. Newman, however, was not trained in the scholastic tradition, being rooted in a more empirical tendency of British thought. As he put it, his «subject is assent», as distinct from merely logical inference, and he interpreted this as a matter of investigating «what the mind does [...] when it makes an act of faith» (GA 99). Moreover, such an inquiry into what Lonergan will often call the «operations» of human understanding, in Newman's blunt words, «must take the constitution of the human mind as we find it, and not as we may judge it ought to be» (GA 216). The invitation is to pay attention to what we are doing when we are knowing, and this was to become a central Lonergan emphasis in *Insight* and later. In his preface to *Method* he voiced the hope that «many readers will find in themselves the dynamic structure of which I write», adding that «I am concerned not with

the objects that theologians expound but with the operations that theologians perform» (MT xii). Newman, in his more literary and rhetorical style, was equally focussed on the performance of ordinary thinking as it journeys towards truth.

Cognitional structure. In Newman's words assent is «definite» and «normal», and the journey towards truth «is a living growth, not a mechanism; and its instruments are mental acts, not the formulas and contrivances of language» (GA 350). He also evokes the operations involved in the process of knowing, speaking of the pleasure involved in experiencing «successive steps of discovery» (GA 207) and how assent is «an act of the mind as admits of being developed into certitude» (GA 214). Here we are close to what Lonergan will call cognitional structure and to his crucial distinction between a hypothesis or act of insight and the subsequent and fuller verification or affirmation of truth.

Learning from self-awareness. The young Lonergan in his reading of the *Grammar* would surely have relished the constant stress on appropriation of one's «own experiences» as «psychological facts» (GA 385). In tune with the rediscovery of self in nineteenth-century culture in general, Newman stated his starting point: «If I do not use myself, I have no other self to use. My only business is to ascertain what I am, in order to put it to use» (GA 347). He goes on to express the same idea more strongly: «we must appeal to himself, as a fact, and not to any antecedent theory, in order to find what is the law of his mind» (GA, 350). Later on he adds that he wanted simply to view the facts «in the medium of my primary mental experiences» (GA 409). As we have seen, a similar pedagogy rooted in actual cognitive performance became central for Lonergan. *Insight* can be said to be a set of intellectual exercises to be undertaken by the reader (on the analogy of Ignatian spiritual exercises). The first chapter of *Method in Theology* also invites «the reader to discover in himself» through «a heightening of consciousness» the unfolding of one's own operations in doing theology (MT 20, 25). Newman was always in quest of a non-external or personalist epistemology to counter a culture of emerging positivism. To meet this same challenge Lonergan would offer his distinction between the data of sense and the data of consciousness. Indeed he once remarked that his whole procedure was basically «a matter of deriving terms and relations from the data of consciousness».²⁷

One should add that both authors express reservations about the term «introspection». Newman cautioned that «introspection of our intellectual operations is not the best of means for preserving us from intellectual hesitation» (GA 216). Lonergan is more downright in his rejection of introspec-

²⁷ *Language Truth and Meaning*, ed. Ph. McShane, Dublin, 1972, 312.

tion as implying the «myth» of «inward inspection», but he proposes that it can have a more fruitful significance as «the process of objectifying the contents of consciousness» (MT 8). Yet again we are in the presence of affinities that become more sophisticated in the more ambitious horizons of the Canadian theologian.

Beliefs as valid knowledge. Both Newman and Lonergan mention how people believe in maps, without actually having surveyed the whole terrain, as an example of how most of what we take as human knowledge is taken on trust (GA 294; Ins 728; MT 42). There is so much that «we commonly take for granted», says Newman, including «our art of life» or the culturally inherited assumptions by which we live (GA 53-54). Such socially accepted beliefs are by their nature notional rather than real assents, but they can nonetheless be «genuine» (GA 57) and Newman insists on the normality of such unverified belief along the way to different kinds of certitude. In *Insight* Lonergan offers a lengthy treatment of belief in his chapter dealing with the religious or redemptive solution to the evils of history. Belief is seen as an essential form of human collaboration within a «self-correcting process of learning» (Ins 728). In a 1970 lecture, just after discussing Newman's *The Idea of a University*, he adds that the «necessary condition for that collaboration is belief» (2C 185). Two years previously he had reflected at length on «Belief: today's issue», arguing that «there is as large a proportion of belief in science as in common sense» (2C 89). *Method in Theology* also has a section on beliefs stressing, among other themes, the historical and «social character of human knowledge» (MT 43). Later still, he makes an important distinction between faith and religious beliefs, proposing that because religious love precedes the knowledge which gives birth to faith, beliefs are separate and in a sense secondary to faith (MT 119, 123). One could multiply quotations from both authors. Our point is simple: here is another notable affinity between Newman and Lonergan, even though, as always, the later thinker offers a more elaborate theoretical framework for his discussions of belief.

Centrality of judgment. Various writers on the relationship of Newman to Lonergan have highlighted the act of judgement as the major point of convergence between them. In one of his rare references to Newman in his study of Aquinas, Lonergan noted that insight was a direct act of understanding into phantasm, but «the *intelligere* from which the judgment proceeds is a reflective and critical act of understanding not unlike the act of Newman's illative sense».²⁸ Years later in 1958, he described the *Grammar* as «a classic upon the act of judgment», which is «rich on the antecedent

²⁸ B. LONERGAN, *Verbum: Word and Idea in Aquinas*, CWL 2, eds. Fr.E. Crowe, R.M. Doran, Toronto, 1997, 60.

process of reflection involved in judgments». Then responding to a question he elaborated on this point more personally:

«I believe that my account of reflective understanding is, in different terms, but roughly equivalent to, what Newman calls the illative sense, but in different terms. Newman was concerned with that same problem. What is the ground of assent? The ground of assent is grasping the sufficiency of the evidence, and I worked this into a formula for an insight, the virtually unconditioned, which eliminates the metaphors».²⁹

In the *Grammar* Newman had praised judgement as «the architectonic faculty» of which the «illative sense, or right judgment in ratiocination, is one branch» (GA 342). More provocatively he adds that «there is no ultimate test of truth besides the testimony born to truth by the mind itself» (GA 350), which again he identifies with «the trustworthiness of the Illative Sense» (GA 359). This human capacity goes beyond scientific procedures because it judges when the accumulation of probabilities is «sufficient for certitude» (GA 411). It determines «the limit of converging probabilities and the reasons sufficient for a proof» (GA 360). We are as close as makes no difference to what Lonergan will call the exhausting of relevant questions and hence a virtually unconditioned truth. In this crucial area of judgement Lonergan never abandoned this discovery that he made in Newman, even though he went on to develop it in more Thomistic terms and in the light of scientific procedures.

Religion and theology. Newman uses that favourite word of Lonergan's – appropriation – several times, and on one occasion in connection with a distinction between religion and theology that Lonergan will use in a different way: a dogma of faith is «appropriated as a reality, by the religious imagination; it is held as a truth, by the theological intellect» (GA 98). For Newman theology deals with the notional, whereas religion is a zone of personal commitment which puts one in contact with the real. Lonergan would qualify this in his *Method in Theology*, proposing that theology is a reflection on religion, mediating between religious experience and culture. He would not see theology as narrowly notional: although religious conversion is not one of his eight functional specialties, it becomes the hinge of his empirical theology, and the fifth phase of foundations involves the objectification of the core religious experience of conversion.

From real assent to real conversion. The long term fruitfulness of Lonergan's encounter with the *Grammar* links up with what can be called his own conversion to conversion, or the shift from notional to real think-

²⁹ B. LONERGAN, , *Understanding and Being: the Halifax lectures on Insight*, CWL 5, eds. E.A. Morelli, M.D. Morelli, Toronto, 1990, 109, 351.

ing. He remarked in 1973 that he «had become something of an existentialist» from his study of the *Grammar* (2C 276). In a series of interviews two years before his death he underlined the importance of Newman in these words: «I was looking for someone who had some common sense, and knew what he was talking about. And what was Newman talking about? About judgement as assent; about real apprehension and notional apprehension, notional assent and real assent. He was answering the liberal view that all judgements are more or less probable but nothing is certain».³⁰ One year earlier in a more formal paper entitled «Pope John's Council», he had elaborated on the same idea in a passage worth quoting at some length. The context is a discussion of the struggle involved to arrive at authenticity, whether personally or communally.

«In this campaign one does well to turn to John Henry Cardinal Newman's *Grammar of Assent* and, specifically, to the passages in which he distinguishes notional apprehension from real apprehension, and notional assent from real assent. For the barriers to enlightenment are merely notional apprehension and merely notional assent [...]. On the other hand, the attainment of enlightenment is the attainment of real apprehension, real assent, and the motivation to live out what we have learnt. It is brought about through regular and sustained meditation on what it really means to be a Christian, a real meaning to be grasped not through definitions and systems but through the living words and deeds of our Lord, our Lady, and the saints [...]. So gradually we replace shallowness and superficiality, weakness and self-indulgence, with the imagination and the feelings, with the solid knowledge and heartfelt willingness of a true follower of Christ».³¹

This is the language of religious conversion as explored in *Method in Theology*. In other words Lonergan's major proposal for the renewal of theology – to pay attention to the foundational religious experience of conversion – had its predecessor in Newman's advocacy of a real assent as opposed to a merely notional one. The later Lonergan transforms the emphasis on real assent into the more existential language of religious commitment.

Conscience and the level of values. In a very similar way the importance Newman gave to moral conscience is broadened into Lonergan's emphasis on the existential or decisional level of self-transcendence. In this respect one of his clearest statements came while responding to questions during the Dublin summer school of 1971: «My fourth level of consciousness [...] is probably the same as what Newman calls conscience. However, I do not mean that Newman thought these things out in my categories».³² A final

³⁰ *Caring about Meaning*, 14.

³¹ B. LONERGAN, *A Third Collection*, ed. Fr.E. Crowe, London, 1985, 326. Future references will be given in the text with the abbreviation 3C.

example on this crucial role for values comes from a text of 1977: «the kind of knowledge by which people live their lives [...] is the knowledge of which Newman wrote in his *Grammar of Assent*» (3C 195). Once more Lonergan's Newman is recognised as having a natural feel for how knowledge transcends the merely cognitive.

The drama of the full self. One of the passages of the *Grammar* that Lonergan quotes in his 1929 paper concerns the inseparability of intellect from moral dispositions in Newman: the rays of truth «stream in upon us through the medium of our moral as well as our intellectual being» (GA 311). For Newman dispositions are vitally important in the journey towards religious truth: people differ from one another in principles «of a personal character» (GA 413), and hence a convergence of «sentiments, intellectual and moral» constitute an essential «preparation» for pondering the evidence for religious faith (GA, 417). In his more ambitious essay on Newman, Lonergan offered a stronger formulation of the same emphasis: «The essential morality of assent is the supreme contention of the *Grammar of Assent*. Assent is moral in its prerequisite of moral living [...]. The right assent is not according to rule but by the act of a living mind».³² Here we are close to what Lonergan much later will call the «foundational reality» for theology in action, in the shape of the three conversions, religious, moral, and intellectual (MT 267). This links up with his insistence that a «deliberate decision about one's horizon» is necessary before the recognition of Christian faith (MT 269). The converted self is different from the unconverted or drifting self, and is thus more open to the gift of God. Where an older theology put conceptual proof at centre stage, Lonergan replaces this with the drama of personal conversion. Both authors imply that any divorce between the intellectual and the existential or moral realms leads to a stunted version of humanity as well as to a reductive picture of human knowing.

Self-transcendence blocked by bias. Both Newman and Lonergan ponder what distinguishes human beings from animals (GA 348-9; MT 104) and reply in terms of a capacity to grow responsibly beyond one's starting point. Lonergan was to explore the upward achievement of human self-transcendence as finding both its fulfilment and its dismantling in the gift of God's love. Newman had moved in a similar direction using a different vocabulary. He speaks of the human person as «a being of progress» who gradually

³² From the typescript of the sessions in the Dublin Lonergan Centre, quotation from p. 63.

³³ From fragments of the lost essay, as cited by R.M. LIDDY, *Transforming Light*, 39. Interestingly, the expression «the living mind» does not seem to occur in the *Grammar*, but is found in the same university sermon of Newman referred to in the 1929 essay. It comes in a passage where Newman stresses the impossibility of doing justice to discourse about God within a merely analytical approach, just as one can only give a «very rude description of the living mind, and its feelings, thoughts and reasonings» (*Fifteen Sermons*, 268).

«advances to the fulness of his original destiny»: it is «his gift to be the creator of his own sufficiency; and to be emphatically self-made» (GA 349). What Newman sees as a «living growth» (GA 350) Lonergan explores in terms of the achievement of authenticity.

But both thinkers are acutely aware of the fragility of this adventure of human change and both of them use the term «bias» for what blocks the thrust of self-transcendence. The *Grammar* diagnoses that «both the moral and the intellectual sanction are liable to be biased by personal inclinations and motives» and when this remains undetected, a person's mind will «remain under the power of prejudice or delusion» (GA 234). Even though there are no direct references by Lonergan to such an analysis on the part of Newman, in *Insight* substantial sections of Chapter 7 explore the dangers of bias: «while there is progress and while its principle is liberty, there also is decline and its principle is bias» (Ins 260). In *Method* he asked how theology could help «abolish the organization of human living on the basis of competing egoisms» (MT 10).

Another angle on the tensions of history can be found in a 1937 essay entitled «Pantôn Anakephalaiôsis». It offered a Pauline metaphysic of human solidarity, in the course of which Lonergan argued that «the achievements and the errors of the past live on into the present».³⁴ In this light he envisaged a philosophy of history that would explore how one dominant idea can be replaced by another in the dialectic of culture. The text offered a more personal example: «it takes a Newman some fifteen years of very slow progress to arrive at the truth of Catholicism, so great is the all pervasive power of traditional mentality».³⁵ Implicit here is Lonergan's sense of the uphill struggle against cultural decline or distortion. It is also one of his rare comments on Newman's conversion, and of course conversion in a wider sense was to become a central concern of Lonergan's later theology.

Additional developments

If during his early years Lonergan had written some essays directly on Newman, in his later years he was surely aware of having transcended or transformed this inheritance. On several occasions he noted the limits or at least the incompleteness of Newman's approach, not as a critique of his always admired predecessor, but simply as a clarification. Thus in an interview of 1971 he placed Newman, together with Augustine, in the category of a «common sense» thinker who was also «a beautiful rhetorician» (2C 227). In other words, both these early influences on Lonergan had remained

³⁴ p. 4 of the typescript consulted in the Lonergan Centre, Dublin.

³⁵ *Ibid.*, 6.

within the realm of reflective communication, speaking descriptively from and to human experience; it is a valuable level of inquiry, but one which does not confront the «systematic exigence» which gives birth to theory. Still less does common sense envisage the «methodical exigence» which leads to the realm of «interiority», where the focus is on the operations of the intending subject. Lonergan's claim here is that where Newman and Augustine offered their rich insights in an unsystematic horizon, Aquinas, like Aristotle, pushed questioning into the realm of theory, and what Lonergan himself means by «method» is basically the need for common sense and theory to be grounded in interiority (MT 83).

This article has concentrated on the principal affinities between Newman and Lonergan, which have to do largely with an epistemology capable of defending faith. However there were other aspects of Newman which Lonergan admired and occasionally commented upon. To indicate further areas for exploration, let me mention three such parallels: the awareness of development in theology; what is lost when theology is excluded from the frontiers of thought; the larger dangers lurking in our dominant cultural assumptions. Indeed each of them can also serve to illustrate what has just been proposed: how Lonergan assimilated but transformed and transcended the wisdom he gleaned from Newman.

For the Canadian a key revolution in modern theology stemmed from the challenge of historical consciousness and he once related this to Newman's ground breaking work on development of doctrine, remarking that the new age in Catholic theology «dates not from 1965 but rather from 1845».³⁶ For Lonergan, however, Newman's initial recognition of historical movement in thought was to evolve into his sense of a radically different context for theology. On countless occasions he speaks of the transition from a «classicist» notion of culture to a more «empirical» and «pluralist» one.³⁷ The older approach based itself on certain assumptions about the superiority of western culture, together with its normativity and permanence. According to this way of thinking historical change was always a secondary phenomenon and diversity of cultures would sooner or later be overcome by education. But the insight that all meanings and values are culturally conditioned put an end to this ingenuous non-historicism. To rethink foundations in the light of a new pluralism became a core thrust of Lonergan's work and takes him well beyond the relatively safer world of Newman. Indeed the great Cardinal retained some of the hallmarks of cultural «classicism» in spite of his brilliant recognition of historical evolution in theology. Although Lonergan does not say so, this account of the classi-

³⁶ B. LONERGAN, «A New Pastoral Theology» in CWL 17, 238.

³⁷ See for example *Method in Theology*, 301.

cist would seem largely applicable to Newman: he is «convinced that circumstances are somehow accidental and that, beyond them, there is some substance or kernel or root that fits in with classicism assumptions of stability, fixity, immutability» (MT 301). By contrast, Lonergan found himself forced to create more theoretical tools to confront this cultural crisis.

Another theme that Lonergan refers to in some of his later essays is what he calls Newman's «theorem», which held that «the omission of a significant discipline from the university curriculum left a blind spot» (2C 148). This refers back to Newman's Dublin discourses entitled *The Idea of a University*, where he noted with alarm the tendency to banish theology from universities and argued that such an absence in the intellectual community provoked a self-mutilation of the horizons of wisdom. If this marginalisation of the faith dimension became the norm, universities would remain stunted and impoverished in their agenda. Lonergan takes Newman's diagnosis and expands it as a perspective on the pluralist complexity of today.

«Positively, Newman advanced that human knowing was a whole with its parts organically related, and this accords with the contemporary phenomenological notion of horizon, that one's perceptions are functions of one's outlook [...]. On the negative side, Newman asked what would happen if a significant part of knowledge were omitted, overlooked, ignored, not just by some individual but by the cultural community» (2C 142).

Going on to summarise Newman, he lists three consequences: ignorance of the discipline, in this case theology; a mutilation of the organic unity of knowledge; a distortion in the perspective of other disciplines who would seek to perform a function outside their field. One thinks of how some eminent scientists become gurus concerning religion or its futility, often without having the slightest acquaintance with the riches of theology. In this light Lonergan insists that not only is religion «part of an authentic humanism» but that theology is «pertinent to the human sciences» (2C 148). Without it the superstructural embodiments of culture, such as universities, are simply avoiding the full range of human need.³⁸ Newman offered his analysis at a point in time when universities were just beginning to dethrone theology from its previous centrality. Lonergan witnessed a more drastic secularisation of learning and was concerned with responding, on many levels, to the cultural wounds inherited from secular modernity.

In this light, a further kinship between the two thinkers has to do with

³⁸ On another occasion in 1970 Lonergan commented in similar terms that «secularism [...] mutilates knowledge» and causes «distortion in what remains» (*A Second Collection*, 185).

their struggles against anthropological reductions in their respective cultural contexts. Just as Newman sought to resist a closed rationalism and a corroding liberalism, Lonergan pointed to the absence of crucial conversions in contemporary culture. For him there are three crucial and ascending search-zones – of truth, freedom and love – and genuine wisdom in all three involves an escape from observer-stance models of exploration. In those three dimensions of existence the adventure of authenticity involves the transformation of the subject, not just an apparently neutral language-game. This insistence on personal engagement in the search for truth or ethics or religious faith was less explicitly elaborated in Newman but was nevertheless one of the intuitive and constant hallmarks of his approach.

To sum up: Newman was the first major author that fired the intellectual imagination of the young Lonergan, and this encounter left an indelible mark. It was not so much a question of discipleship and of an energising confirmation of his own *forma mentis*. In Newman he found a companion spirit, someone outside the camp of traditional scholastic philosophy and someone with an empirical and phenomenological bent. The word «influence» is not the best term to describe the complex history of the impact of Newman on Lonergan. As we have argued here, it is more a question of a style of thinking and of an affinity of concerns and temperaments. But Lonergan's own evolving horizons of thought led him beyond this fruitful initial affinity towards transcendental foundations of thought. Thus he moved from the descriptive categories of Newman towards more demanding and explanatory horizons: in his own words, «descriptive procedure was superseded by explanatory» (Ins 358). Lonergan frequently referred to the project of Pope Leo XIII: *vetera novis augere et perficere*. In Newman he had found his first great interlocutor to spur him into fulfilling that hope. As in many later encounters, Lonergan appropriated his mentor's vision of the *vetera* and went on to explore his own challenging vistas of the *nova*.

Pontificia Università Gregoriana
Piazza della Pilotta, 4
00187 Roma

Michael Paul GALLAGHER S.I.

SUMMARY

This essay explores the relationship between Bernard Lonergan and his first intellectual mentor, John Henry Newman. It seeks to go beyond the question of explicit references or direct influences in order to identify major areas of affinity between the two thinkers. These include the limitations of logic, attention to cognitive structure, the centrality of judgement, the dialectic of self transcendence distorted by biased attitudes, and the parallel between real assent and conversion. Lonergan appropriated and transformed the liberating foundations that he discovered through his youthful reading of Newman. An empirical and psychological style of thinking characterised both authors, but Lonergan went beyond the largely descriptive categories of Newman in order to offer more explanatory horizons of method and interiority.

L'article examine la relation de Bernard Lonergan à John Henry Newman, son premier inspirateur intellectuel. Il cherche à aller plus loin que les questions de références explicites ou des influences directes pour identifier les domaines majeurs où les deux penseurs ont des affinités, ce qui inclut les limitations de la logique, l'attention aux structures cognitives, la centralité du jugement, la dialectique de l'auto-transcendance que dévient des attitudes erronées, le parallèle entre l'assentiment réel et la conversion. Lonergan s'appropri et transforma les fondements libérateurs qu'il découvrit au long de sa lecture de jeunesse de Newman. Un même ligne de pensée, empirique et psychologique, caractérise les deux auteurs, mais Lonergan va au delà des vastes catégories descriptives de Newman afin d'ouvrir des horizons plus larges à l'exploration de la méthode et de l'intériorité.